
Premier League: 10 talking points from the weekend's action

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Carrick fails to take advantage ...

The 199th Manchester derby was defined by two controversial refereeing decisions: Phil Foden's first-half red card for kicking out at Bruno Fernandes, and the VAR intervention to award Erling Haaland's winning goal despite Enzo Fernández appearing to interfere with play from an offside position. In both cases, a healthy dose of common sense might have led to a different outcome – and Pro Ref later admitted that Haaland's goal should not have stood. Still, it's tough to argue that the final result was harsh on United. Foden's dismissal gave the hosts a huge opportunity they failed to take, their best chance falling to Bryan Mbeumo in stoppage time. Michael Carrick began his reign with [a 2-0 home derby win](#) against 11 men in January, so this felt like a backwards step for the manager, unable to find a way to control the game. Carrick also bemoaned City's two days of extra rest after Champions League games this week – but chose to keep Fernandes and others on for 90 minutes in the 4-0 stroll past Sabah. United's next two league games are away at Fulham and at home to Spurs. Carrick will need to be smarter to stop an early-season wobble becoming something more serious. **Niall McVeigh**

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... while Maresca's masterplan pays off

Foden's red card also posed a big test for Enzo Maresca, overseeing his first derby as [Manchester City](#) manager. After a solid but unspectacular start to the league season, this could have become a painful afternoon with his team down to 10 men. Instead, the Italian made smart decisions to secure a galvanising result – and keep pace with Arsenal, both teams already edging clear of their expected rivals. Maresca made just one change in the first 80 minutes, but bringing on Iliman Ndiaye for Rayan Cherki gave his team a more direct threat on the break. Fellow new signings Enzo Fernández and Elliot Anderson have settled quickly, the latter imperious in midfield during a second half where City rarely looked short-handed. At the back, Marc Guéhi barely put a foot wrong as Maresca's side showed a solidity that had been lacking. The manner of Haaland's winner was fortunate, to say the least, but the visitors' second-half display deserved all three points. **NMc**

Free-scoring Seagulls dunk on Coventry

On another day, any of the excellent individual goals from Charalampos Kostas, Malick Yalcouyé and Yasin Ayari could have been the showstopper in Brighton's rout of Coventry. But none could compare to Lewis Dunk's sensational 35-yard piledriver into the top corner. For a centre-back to even consider shooting from where he did is ridiculous, but Dunk insisted he has "that sort of shot in my locker", with Fabian Hürzeler saying everyone at the club knows all about the shooting technique he possesses. Dunk was one of five different goalscorers on Sunday as Brighton continue to show they can do things differently to last season, when Danny Welbeck was their chief attacking threat with 13 Premier League goals. Already in this campaign, eight different Brighton players have scored in just four league games. And who really needs a star striker when your centre-back can hit a ball like that? **Ben Bloom**

Arteta's 'sadness' unfair to Sunderland

Referees are supposed to be clamping down on grappling, holding and shirt-pulling at dead balls this season – but until the 58th minute at the Stadium of Light on Saturday both [Sunderland](#) and Arsenal got away with plenty at corners and throws. The irony was that when John Brooks finally penalised Ezri Konsa for hauling Dan Ballard down at a throw and awarded Sunderland a penalty, subsequently endorsed by a VAR check, it proved contentious. There was a strong case for arguing that Ballard's clever "judo roll" had landed the admittedly far from innocent Konsa in deep trouble. No matter that David Raya's brilliant save ensured Enzo Le Fée's ensuing penalty proved academic; Mikel Arteta subsequently cut a study in righteous indignation. Going over the top, he said he felt "sad" for football and talked about wanting to "protect the game". When, two minutes after Le Fée's miss, Bruno Guimarães curled in a superlative shot Arsenal were en route to a 2-0 win sealed by Bukayo Saka's late penalty and their immaculate start to the season continued. Sunderland, though, had played well and deserved more credit from a less than magnanimous Arteta. **Louise Taylor**

Midfield fragility haunts Iraola

Andoni Iraola will inevitably discover some unwelcome truths in the learning stage of his [Liverpool](#) reign. A second successive Premier League draw at Anfield – their seventh from 12 games in 2026 – revealed several, from Kostas Tsimikas' unreliability as a starter to the porous nature of a central midfield pairing of Ryan Gravenberch and Dominik Szoboszlai. Iraola had to make changes given the ridiculously tight turnaround from Wednesday's Champions League win over Atlético Madrid, his first experience of having to do so with Liverpool, and the absence of Alexis Mac Allister had more of a destabilising effect than he might have imagined. Gravenberch and Szoboszlai offered minimal resistance to a Fulham team that cut through with ease and, together with Florian Wirtz, offered little to an ineffective Liverpool attack assembled at huge expense. There will be further changes when Tottenham visit in the Carabao Cup on Tuesday. Teenage midfielder Trey Nyoni, impressive in pre-season, should get an opportunity to show he can be a viable alternative the next time Mac Allister is rested. **Andy Hunter**

Miss and Tel: De Zerbi's Spurs still scoreless

Roberto De Zerbi insisted there "is not a problem" between him and Mathys Tel, when nobody had seriously suggested there was. "I love Mathys as a player, as a guy," the Tottenham manager said. Still, it was not a good day for Tel against [Everton](#). Dropped from the starting XI, he received an on-pitch tutorial from De Zerbi in how to play as a No 9. The Tottenham manager had moved Tel there in the closing stages after initially introducing him in his favoured left wing role. Play on the shoulder, attack the six-yard box, was the gist of De Zerbi's advice. Spurs's toothlessness at the sharp end of their formation was not on Tel. The real worry was Dominic Solanke and how he ghosted through another Premier League game. Omar Marmoush was also ineffective; first on the left, then briefly as the No 9 after Solanke was withdrawn. Solanke has been undermined by injuries, but his return of 12 league goals since his £55m arrival in August 2024 is not good enough. **David Hytner**

Sage wisdom under scrutiny at Palace

Crystal Palace's defenders committed the cardinal sin of not playing to the whistle when they allowed Ipswich to equalise during the first half of Saturday's costly 3-2 defeat. It was just the latest example of the bad habits that are creeping in since Pierre Sage's arrival as manager. While the Frenchman promised to speak to Axel Disasi this week after his reckless red card in the first half cost Palace dear, it was surprising to hear Sage admit his players had made the same mistake during training this week. "I had this discussion with them because they did the same thing in a session. I told them to continue to play," he said. "Because of the VAR now, I prefer they deflect the ball [out] for a corner and then ask the referee if they were offside or not." Palace are lacking leadership at the back after selling Maxence Lacroix to Chelsea and have conceded seven goals in Sage's first two matches at home. He must find a solution to their defensive woes without Disasi, who is set to miss their next three Premier League matches due to suspension. **Ed Aarons**

Chelsea's defence still looks unserious

Chelsea do not relish the art of defending enough. Hull City's first goal on Saturday was a case in point. Malo Gusto was outmuscled by Ryan Giles and Mohamed Belloumi equalised when Jorrel Hato misjudged the Hull left-back's cross. Xabi Alonso called it soft. The Chelsea manager replaced Hato at half-time but the problems are not down to one individual. Emiliano Martínez, signed as Robert Sanchez's replacement, is yet to convince in goal. Wesley Fofana still flatters to deceive, Levi Colwill is feeling his way back from injury and Maxence Lacroix was surprisingly on the bench against Hull. Chelsea have conceded 12 goals in Alonso's first six games in all competitions. They remain unserious. **Jacob Steinberg**

Match report: [Chelsea 2-2 Hull](#)

McAtee finally finds his feet at Forest

Oliver Glasner consistently name-checked James McAtee before a ball was kicked this season, adamant the £30m arrival from Manchester City last summer could finally make a splash in a [Nottingham Forest](#) shirt. Supporters were sceptical but his performance in their first victory of the season, at Aston Villa on Saturday, was further evidence of a player revitalised. Glasner is convinced the 23-year-old can thrive in the quarterback role he gave Adam Wharton at Crystal Palace. McAtee has started all four league matches this season, twice as many as he managed across the entire last campaign; he was hooked at half-time in successive starts against Utrecht and Wrexham either side of the turn of the year. But against Villa, McAtee oozed confidence and relished dictating the game. Glasner represents McAtee's fifth Forest manager in 13 months but in the Austrian he has one of his biggest fans. **Ben Fisher**

Match report: [Aston Villa 1-2 Nottingham Forest](#)

"Many teams struggle against [Bournemouth](#)," said Brentford's Vitaly Janelt. That has been true of all four opponents faced in Marco Rose's Premier League tenure. And yet the wait for a first win continues. "If you watch our games, I think it's a joy," said Rose afterwards. This week, his squad jets off to face Real Sociedad in the Europa League, fulfilling the dream of fans and the club's owner. Bill Foley. Rose, one of the game's optimists, refused to cast blame on Djordje Petrovic's goalkeeping errors for Kevin Schade's double, instead looking ahead to Thursday: "A special night for the club against top opposition. It's a tough stadium. Top atmosphere, intense opponent, a good team with Spanish national team players." Bournemouth might well find life easier in Europe. As Justin Kluivert remarked: "It's lovely to play in this team. We are front-footed, we press, we don't just let it be a slow game, we go for it." **John Brewin**

Match report: [Bournemouth 2-2 Brentford](#)

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
1	Arsenal	4	7	12
2	Man City	4	6	12
3	Hull	4	3	8
4	Brighton	4	8	7
5	Chelsea	4	1	7
6	Brentford	4	3	6
7	Liverpool	4	2	6
8	Everton	4	2	6
9	Ipswich	4	-3	6
10	Newcastle	3	2	5
11	Leeds	3	1	5
12	Nottm Forest	4	0	5
13	Man Utd	4	0	4
14	Sunderland	4	-2	4
15	AFC Bournemouth	4	-1	3
16	Crystal Palace	4	-5	3

Pos	Team	P	GD	Pts
17	Tottenham Hotspur	4	-5	2
18	Fulham	4	-3	1
19	Aston Villa	4	-6	1
20	Coventry	4	-10	0

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